

Propositional eternalism, temporalism, necessitism and contingentism

Handout for *Time and Modality* seminar

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1 Unfinished business: psychological arguments against the date theory

The “date theory”:

When uttered at a certain instant i , a present-tense sentence ϕ expresses the same proposition that would be expressed by the sentence ‘At t , ϕ ’ relative to an assignment that maps the variable t to i .

Some observations that seem problematic for the date theory:

- (i) ‘Annie thinks it is raining’ seems false at noon in a circumstance where Annie has lost track of the time and thinks, at noon, that it is 3pm, and Annie thinks that it is sunny at 3pm (she is sitting in the sun) but that it was raining at noon.
- (ii) ‘Annie thought it was raining’ is ambiguous. It has a “two-time” reading where it is true if Annie thought, in the past, that it was raining during some particular further-past interval. It also has a “simultaneous” reading where only one past time is relevant. On this reading, it’s true if Annie was thinking to herself ‘It is raining!’ at that time, but it is not true if Annie had lost track of the time and thinking to herself ‘It’s not raining, but it was raining on such-and-such date at such-and-such time’, referring to the time in question. (Note that other languages use the present tense for the embedded sentence in the simultaneous reading.)
- (iii) ‘Arthur is relieved that his dental surgery is over’ seems consistent with ‘There is no time t such that Arthur is relieved that his dental surgery is over by t ’.

2 Just another Frege puzzle?

Analogy: the theory that ‘Hesperus is bright’ and ‘Phosphorus is bright’ express the same proposition faces the problem that ‘Hammurabi believes that Hesperus is bright’ seems to have different truth conditions from ‘Hammurabi believes that Phosphorus is bright’.

Responses:

- (i) Pragmatic Millianism: ‘Hammurabi doesn’t believe that Phosphorus is bright’ is literally false but acceptable for some other reason.
- (ii) Error-theoretic Millianism: ‘Hammurabi doesn’t believe that Phosphorus is bright’ seems acceptable just because we wrongly believe that false proposition it literally expresses.
- (iii) Contextualism: ‘believes’ introduces context-sensitivity; the choice of names affects how this context-sensitivity is most naturally resolved.

How do the analogues of these responses look for the date theorist?

Propositional eternalism without the date theory? a Fregean approach

- For each time t , there is a proposition that is (i) necessarily, true iff it is raining at t , and (ii) necessarily, believed at t only by those who believe that it is then raining under a “present-tensed mode of presentation” (and similarly for other attitudes).
 - What, if anything, does it take to believe this proposition at a different time?

- When we utter a present tense sentence, the proposition expressed is of this sort.
- Propositions of this sort are designated by present-tensed 'that' clauses and by the 'that' clauses in past-tensed attitude reports on their "simultaneous" readings.

3 'Centred propositions'

Lewis's concept of *self-ascription*.

- For Lewis: a relation between person-stages and properties that could be had by person-stages.
- A more neutral version: a relation between people, times, and functions from people and times to eternal propositions.
- Note of caution: 'John believes that his pants are on fire' certainly has *a* reading on which it can be true even if John doesn't self-ascribe *having pants that are on fire*.
 - It's controversial whether it has any reading that *does* require this.
 - If it does have such a reading, it's controversial whether it involves a different resolution of structural syntactic ambiguity.
- Lewis's account of "*de re* belief" in terms of self-ascription.

4 Arguments from propositional anaphora for temporalism/contingentism

- (1) a. It's raining. — That's true, but won't be true tomorrow. (Cappellen and Hawthorne)
 b. It's raining. — That's true, but wouldn't have been true if those southerly winds had kept up.
- (2) a. It's raining. — That's true, but isn't true where Sally is
 b. Movies like this always make me fall asleep. — That's true, but isn't true for everyone.
- (3) a. I drove a Honda Accord for many years. — I used to drive that, but now I drive a Camry.
 b. I drove my mother's car for many years. — I only drove that for a few months after I got my license, then I got my own car.
 c. Fred had to replace the piece of plastic connecting the screen of his laptop to the keyboard. — I had to replace that too.
 d. I found the first ten minutes of the interview tough going. — Funny, in my interview, that was the best part.
 e. The last speaker of the day is a philosopher of language. — On every other day, that speaker has been a metaphysician.
- (4) a. I believed that my mother was the nicest mother in the world. — I believed that too, and it was true!
 b. Fred figured out that his illness was due to a virus. — I believed that too, but in my case it turned out to be false.

5 Arguments from propositional anaphora for eternalism/necessitism

Mark Richard:

[S]uppose that at midnight, Mary utters the sentence 'Clinton is president', and at dawn,

she utters the sentence '[I was wrong,] Clinton was not president at midnight'. At dawn, we can report to Clinton,

(R) At midnight, Mary said that you were president, but now she denies it/that/what she said at midnight.

- P1 We spoke truly and literally in uttering R.
- P2 If we spoke truly and literally in uttering R, there is a proposition that Mary asserted at midnight and denied at dawn.
- P3 If propositional temporalism is true, then at midnight Mary asserted a proposition that is true exactly when Clinton is president.
- P4 Mary did not, at dawn, deny any proposition that is true exactly when Clinton is president.
- P5 Mary asserted only one proposition at midnight.

Schaffer's modal variant of this argument:

- (S) If Gore had won the election in 2000, Mary would have said at t that America chose wisely in 2000, but she actually denied that at t .
- (P1') We spoke truly and literally in uttering S.
- (P2') If we spoke truly and literally in uttering S, there is a proposition that Mary would have asserted at t if Gore had won the election in 2000 which she actually denied at t .
- (P3') If propositional contingentism is true, then if Gore had won, Mary would at t have asserted a proposition that is, necessarily, true if and only if America chose wisely in 2000.
- (P4') Mary did not at t deny any proposition that is, necessarily, true if and only if America chose wisely in 2000.
- (P5') If Gore had won, Mary would have asserted only one proposition at t .

6 Richard's argument from invalidity

- (5) Mary believed that Nixon was president.
Mary still believes everything she once believed.
So, Mary believes that Nixon is president.

7 Arguments concerning utterance truth and correctness

Truth Link: Necessarily, for any utterance u , u is true iff the proposition expressed by u is true.

Stability: Necessarily, if an utterance u expresses the proposition p , then it is *always* the case that u is an utterance and expresses p .

Correctness Link: Necessarily, for any utterance u , u is correct iff the proposition expressed by u is true.

Unfair Punishment: Necessarily, for any act of punishment a , a is unfair iff the target of a is morally innocent.

- (6) Necessarily, for any time t , for any act of punishment a , a is unfair at t iff the target of a is morally innocent at t .
- (7) Necessarily, for any time t , for any act of punishment a , a is unfair at t iff the target of a is morally innocent at the time a is occurring.

- (8) Necessarily, for any utterance u , u is correct iff the proposition expressed by u is true at the time u is occurring.